



**Struggles up front:** Uruguay has struggled for consistency, winning just five of its last 22 matches. Head coach Marcelo Bielsa (right) will look to turn Uruguay's control and defensive solidity into goals. AFP

Leitão Brito, popularly known as Bubista, it aims to build on its reputation as a giant killer on the global stage.

The Blue Sharks will also expect miracles from captain Ryan Mendes, their record goalscorer, while Sidny Lopes Cabral, who honed his defensive skills under Jose Mourinho at Benfica, will man the defence.

This group also sets the stage for a tale of redemption in Marcelo Bielsa, who returns to the World Cup stage for the third time and the first in 16 years. The former Argentina manager, considered one of the most influential managers of the game ever, has been given the task of uplifting the first-ever World Cup winner back to its glory days, with the team making a group-stage exit in the previous edition.

A team in transition, La Celeste has moved on from the ferocity of Edinson Cavani and Luis Suarez and will have Federico Vinas and Rodrigo Aguirre among its potential goalscorers. But its biggest strength will be the midfield, comprising Real Madrid's Federico Valverde — a long-shooting specialist — with Rodrigo Bentancur and Manuel Ugarte likely to be employed as a double pivot.

Uruguay, however, has struggled for consistency, winning just five of its last 22 matches. Despite having veteran defenders like

## ON THE RADAR



### **Lamine Yamal** (Spain)

Spain's most menacing option in the final third, Yamal can dribble past full-backs, break the press and unleash stunning long-range strikes. The Barcelona forward, if fully fit, is expected to remain in contention for individual honours at the World Cup.



### **Dailon Livramento** (Cape Verde)

The 25-year-old forward was Cape Verde's leading goalscorer in the World Cup qualifiers — four goals — and plays in the Portuguese top flight, bringing elite European experience to the table. A much younger and faster alternative to captain Ryan Mendes, he is also known to use his aerial ability — he has a frame of 185cm — for set-piece situations.